

Hannah Arendt's Foundation for a Metaphysics of Evil

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And History will smile to think that this is the species
for which Socrates and Jesus Christ died.

—Julien Benda

The Treason of the Intellectuals

Introduction

The rise of rationalism and the secularism it has sired have combined to reduce the significance of evil to a pathology of the society in which it takes place. Simultaneously, evil is exorcised from human nature and relocated in the contingencies of time and place. The hidden assumption of this view is to make evil a function of human orders, the incidentals of self-selected modes of human organization. Evil is then no longer a depravity of the individual soul, a nature that has turned on itself and others. This gives the organizers of politics, and those who speak for them, an awesome power in shaping human living-together. And if there is anything that separates the moderns from the ancients, it is the hubris of moderns who believe that the human will can overcome nature—even an evil one—through the bureaucratization of goodness: what we call Society.

Before the boon of the social sciences, grounded as they are in nature and thereby bound by it, evil was often elevated to theological legend: it was held to have entered the world due to some divine sanction. Sometimes it was degraded to superstitious mystery, a chthonic avenger, the stuff of tall tales

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to check the "behavior" of the "faithful." With the growth, indeed the dominance, of the modern social sciences, evil has been relocated to the darker regions of the unconscious mind where it is closed to public inspection.

Perhaps it is due to some residuum of the Enlightenment that modernity looks for evil in a transcendent beginning of the historical drama that needs the course of history in order to be overcome. From an ontological perspective, it appears man's burden, indeed an imperative of his temporal salvation, to understand the origin of evil that set the historical process into motion. The modern search for causes, based on a presumption of an absolute knowledge that replaced the tentativeness of premodern understanding, has led to the development of historicist theories aimed at eradicating evil in history. In this sense, evil is not a contingent of history but is seen as the maker of it. This explains man's continual attraction to historical movements; that is, those totalizing theories that posit a beginning and work towards the eradication of evil in history.

Of course such theories are not new, and by themselves they may offer man a foundation for imposing meaning on his existence. They may, once the dynamics are grasped, even offer the illusion of progress. But they do not explain evil. The kind of evil that emerges from totalizing theories finds its source not in the pseudoscientificality proffered by modern ideologies (themselves a product of social scientificity), but in the intellectual mimicry that parallels scientific explanation. This metaphysical operation does not reveal thinking, but its opposite: not stupidity, but banality. While this banality is not new, its political significance lies in the fact that it is now a mass phenomenon. Hannah Arendt's contribution to our understanding of this evil is her discovery that it lies in the operation of the two main totalitarian ideologies of our time: racism, seen as the natural struggle between races, and Communism, understood as a historical conflict of classes.

It is in the operation of the ideological mind where banal murdering can reach monstrous proportions, and leave no trace of conscience or the need for results, which concludes in a metaphysical shallowness. The banal mind turns on a mechanism that confronts Western standards of humanity understood as either a common origin or a shared purpose, that is, a Judeo-Christian assumption or a rationalist intention. Arendt's conclusions in *Eichmann in Jerusalem* (1965) and *The Life of the Mind* (1978) enraged a complacent audience that was content to believe that evil was the result of evil men with evil intent. Her characterization of Adolf Eichmann's murders as banal confronted 2000 years of Judeo-Christian culture that had been accustomed to finding "temptation" or envy as the source of human malevolence. Either personal gain or simple

human meanness had been the standard for slaughter throughout Western history. For a general understanding they served well, even if imprecisely, in explaining human depravity. They also contain an element that facilitates rational understanding. Both seek a result, an object or goal, that directs and justifies the action: material benefits for the one, and personal gratification for the other.

But the banal mind seems to lack calculation beyond the procedure requisite to carrying out certain acts. It has no goal, no future state of affairs beyond the acts assigned to it. It is literally thoughtless and has no long-term objectives in whose light it seeks fulfillment. Arendt turns again to Eichmann, and points up the mental emptiness of his acts: he held "no firm ideological convictions or ... specific evil motives." On the stand in Jerusalem he claimed to be an "idealist," but seemed to believe in nothing.¹ While the consequences of his acts were horrifying, he seemed to make no moral or emotional connection to them. Indeed, he appeared the prototypical mass man and totalitarian mentality Arendt first described in *The Origins of Totalitarianism*. Indeed, as late as 1963 Arendt responded to a criticism of her banality thesis by holding firmly that "Eichmann may very well remain the concrete model of what I have to say."²

The presence of evil was latent in the first two editions (1951, 1958) of her totalitarianism book. Arendt observed in the preface that "an absolute evil appears (absolute because it can no longer be deduced from humanly comprehensible motives)."³ But she modified her characterization of evil in the later (1966) edition. Yet she maintained that evil could be "radical." Indeed, if totalitarianism is an extremity, then so must be the evil of men who practice it: "it is also true that without it [totalitarianism] we might never have known the truly radical nature of evil."⁴ Radical is derived from the Latin, *radix*, meaning deeply rooted. Absolute implies that which is unmitigated by anything else, any salutary virtues or restraint. Thus there is no room for anything but evil. But evil could still remain radical; the mind is the root of man as an ontological category.

Richard Bernstein makes an effort to rescue Arendt's banality characterization from her critics, in part by conjoining it with the idea of "radical evil," which he says, citing Arendt, is the "organized attempt to eradicate the concept and *reality* of being human."⁵ Of course he does not flesh out this "human being." But by 1963 Arendt herself had abandoned the couplet of "radical evil," as Bernstein observes: "I changed my mind and do no longer speak of 'radical evil' ... evil is never 'radical,' that it is extreme, and that it possesses neither depth nor any demonic dimension" (*JP*, 250–251). But my thesis here is that she comes close to rescuing this concept by hedging it between her final work on mental life and her 1954 defense of her

totalitarianism book. "On the Nature of Totalitarianism" is a defense of her book, which was attacked most often by social scientists, but the article hints at the direction she would later take in trying to understand the phenomenon of evil. She warns her readers emphatically, that to understand totalitarianism, more as a condition than a regime, "one need understand only one thing: Totalitarianism is the most radical denial of freedom."⁶

My thesis is contingent on an understanding of the spiritual and moral desiccation of Western culture that preceded Bernstein's hyperconcentration on the twentieth century. Indeed, his ahistorical analysis leads him to ignore the fact, considered so seriously by Arendt, that the path toward totalitarianism was paved centuries before Eichmann.⁷ Following the logic of history as process, Eichmann was not a cause but a result. Arendt is quite clear that the preconditions for totalitarianism can be found in the "non-totalitarian world," and require little more than a willingness to surrender one's mental integrity to the rising ideologies bent on political power, none of which were really successful until the twentieth century. "Such ideologies," she says, "were fully developed before anybody ever heard the word or conceived the notion of totalitarianism."⁸ Equally important, she connects the precondi-tioned mind to "the ever-increasing political and physical homelessness and spiritual and social rootlessness," which is the "one gigantic mass destiny of our time."⁹ This is precisely why Philip Rieff, one of the more gifted sociologists of our day, characterizes *The Origins of Totalitarianism* as a "vast spiritualization of history—that is, her data are organized to reveal the spirit that informs history."¹⁰ He might well have said, as Arendt implies, a "despiritualization" of history, where everything outside of "historical necessity" has "begun to appear lifeless, bloodless, meaningless, and unreal."¹¹

This view was a staple of Arendt's by the time she wrote *The Human Condition*. Thoughtlessness, she says, is among "the outstanding characteristics of our time," and she defines it in part as "the heedless recklessness and hopeless confusion or complacent repetition of 'truths,' which have become trivial and empty."¹² Bernstein develops a kind of linear analysis to explain this thoughtless evil: from superfluosity, to banality, to thoughtlessness itself. But there are no real causal connections offered between the phenomena, which leads him to the unsatisfactory and unsatisfied conclusion that Arendt never provides "a fully satisfactory answer to the question she raised about the relation between thinking and evil."¹³ What seems to baffle him the most is that even if we accept Eichmann's "inability to think," he says, then "[the] primary question that confronts us is how are we to account for this lack" (his emphasis).¹⁴ But his ahistorical analysis, which is more

descriptive than philosophical, leads him away from the fact that the condition of banality in modernity requires a thoughtlessness which renders men superfluous.

One of the defining features of modernity, or "modern age" as Arendt puts it, is the separation of thinking from doing. The new Society, like the new History, requires the process of "unmaking" to provide purposefulness to thoughtless men. As early as *Origins*, the idea of banality was actually already present as a leitmotif for modernity. "Without the possibility of a radical change of role and character," she observes, "the self-willed immersion in the suprahuman forces of destruction seemed to be salvation from the automatic identification with the pre-established functions in society and their utter banality, and at the same time to help destroy the functioning itself" (*Origins*, 331). This gives rise to what she calls a "destructive urge," the modern need to shatter the *tedium vitae* of functional existence. The idea of History, the entirely modern belief in the deterministic movement of man in time, reversed the purpose of homo faber and transforms man into an "unmaker" of the world. This is why she warns us in her last work to reclaim our dignity "from the pseudo-divinity named History of the modern age" by "denying its right to being the ultimate judge" (*Mind*, 216). But more to my point is her warning in *Between Past and Future* to confront "the concept of history with which the modern age hoped to replace the concepts of traditional metaphysics."¹⁵ This is why she developed a rather open disdain for modern philosophy, as well as the modern "debunking sciences," psychology and sociology. She says that modern philosophy "is called upon to compensate for the frustrations of politics and ... life itself" (*Mind*, 160).¹⁶ This means that philosophy was called upon to defend and justify increasingly parochial units of human organization and the operational premise that defines them. This is manifest politically as a shrinkage from the Christian spiritual empire into states, nations, races, and classes, and more constricting sources of identity. Hence, the "modern 'deaths' of—God, metaphysics, and philosophy" became by the twentieth century "the common unexamined assumption of nearly everybody" (*Mind*, 11; see also 177).¹⁷

Hannah Arendt is much less concerned with the resurrection of these modes of understanding the world than she is with revitalizing the fundamental questions posed by them. This is manifest politically in her preface to *Between Past and Future*. She says her concern is to interpret "traditional concepts in order to distill from them anew their original spirit which has so sadly evaporated from the key words of political language" (*BPF*, Preface, 15). She refers here to concepts that actually illuminate their metaphysical provenance in *The Life of the Mind*: "such as freedom and justice, authority and reason,

responsibility and virtue, power and glory" (*BPF*, 15). Without her later effort to plumb the mind these political concepts would have remained, as she says, "empty shells."¹⁸

1.

In *The Life of the Mind*, Arendt claims that the "banality of evil" contained "no thesis or doctrine, although I was dimly aware that it went counter to our tradition of thought—literary, theological, or philosophical—about the phenomenon of evil" (*Mind*, 4). Her "dim awareness" of banal evil was first noticed, not in the Eichmann book, but in *The Origins of Totalitarianism*. She notes that "the aim of totalitarian education has never been to instill convictions but to destroy the capacity to form any" (*Origins*, 468). This is certainly compatible on a general level with what later formed her observation regarding Eichmann's dearth of convictions and the absence of "specific evil motives." This formed her foundation for a new, negative anthropology, "thoughtlessness," of which banality is a manifestation.

Sociologically understood as an uncommon commonness, banality seems to have grown out of that "ideological thinking" that proved one of those "insights of a more general and theoretical nature which now [1958] appears to me to grow directly out of the analysis of the elements of total domination" (*Origins*, Preface). It appears, then, that banality is unbounded or, rather, it is bounded by extremes. At one end George Kateb notes that Eichmann's deeds appear as "unfathomable evil."¹⁹ Yet Arendt seems impressed with the "'manifest shallowness' of the doer" (*Mind*, 4). We appear to be caught between that which has no end and that which has no beginning. Evil is, then, an extremity of some sort. But it is difficult to locate because the radical is often without precedent, or at least without chance of expression as a mass phenomenon. Yet these are not extremes that need to be reconciled; instead they pose a paradox that needs to be comprehended. Theorizing is difficult here; there is no generalization for the unprecedented.

We might put the paradox in the form of a question: How can emptiness of mind lead to a surfeit of evil? This is no mere metaphysical puzzle for it leads to a larger political question. Does total domination create empty minds; or more shockingly, can it only take place under conditions of empty minds? Such questions are not easy, and Western Civilization has been reluctant to probe deeply enough for answers which might dispel its own illusion of progress; an illusion which itself might be the source of the answers. The implications for mass democracy are uneasy to contemplate.

Perhaps we are children of the Enlightenment. Nonrational behavior strikes us as bizarre, perverse, senseless, and sometimes even comical; but we would never classify it as unfathom-

able. To fathom is to apply a scheme, a form, to measure and come to understand. But the kind of evil of which the functionaries of genocide were capable, despite all of the analyses, apparently remains unfathomable. Then are we as helpless as its victims to comprehend, to "reconcile" (Arendt) ourselves to a world in which such crimes are possible?

The Life of the Mind was Hannah Arendt's final effort to treat mental life. Philosophically, it was a last effort to answer this question. Indeed, the first volume, *Thinking*, is an extended meditation on banality's opposite. Obviously this meditation was a painful one for Arendt. Kateb captures this agony, and perhaps the impasse that prompted it, when he notes Arendt's failure to connect thinking directly to good or evil, and her final "dread hunch that much of the worst evil done in the world is done by those who are not capable of thinking." The problem with thinking, its failure, is that it only goes on when we "leave the world."²⁰ But the privacy required for thinking is shattered by the invasiveness of ideological terror, its totality. There is no metaphysical *topos*, no place to think.

Thinking appears to be the first step in the *bios theoretikos*, but only the first step. Thinking's withdrawal from the world makes it the "freest and purest" of human activities precisely because of its aloofness from illusory sense objects. Yet it also retreats from the world of appearances where men encounter others and create a common world. Thinking's alienation from the world has the self-destructive character of turning on itself. Moreover, thinking's detachment from public life denies the very appearances from which it seeks direction, and to which it must return to seek agreement.

Thinking is, then, necessary for what Arendt calls common sense, as in *sensus communis*, because it is essential in the construction of a common world. But it is also solitary, it must exclude others to be free. Thus Arendt leaves us with the rather dubious conclusion that thinking by itself, or its absence alone, is not evil. Are we stuck? Telling us what something is not does not help us fathom what something is. Similarly, while she spends much time tracing the pathologies of Europe to the doorstep of totalitarianism, she describes but never really explains their conclusion in evil. But we might hope to find an outline, some traces in her work which lead to evil when thinking is absent. We are especially concerned here to understand, or penetrate, that *interior domus* of the individual where banality sweeps thinking aside.

2.

As Arendt conceives it, totalitarianism is complete when it is bounded on the one side by "the compulsion of total terror" and on the other side by "the self-coercive force of logical deduction."

Caught in the middle, the individual finds his reality transformed into a fiction because "men lose the capacity of both experience and thought" (*Origins*, 473–474). Hence, totalitarian ideology does not aim at the fanatic, those for whom reality or thinking was never a concern in the first place. Instead, its target is the large mass of individuals who have already lost most convictions, "people for whom the distinction between fact and fiction (i.e., the reality of experience) and the distinction between true and false (i.e., the standards of thought) no longer exist" (*Origins*, 474).

The standards of thought and the reality of experience Arendt sees as having been undermined with the destruction of the old conventionalism, with its emphasis on religious, political, and social institutions. Tradition, the knowables for historical reckoning, serves as anchors (or "guideposts" as she likes to call them) against the irruption of gnostic formulations whose novelty might form the premise for the "unprecedented." Indeed, Arendt is unambiguous about the coeval rise of totalitarian movements with the decline of tradition: "The rise of political movements intent upon replacing the party system, and the development of a new totalitarian form of government, took place against a background of a more or less general, more or less dramatic breakdown of all traditional authorities" (*BPF*, "What is Authority?" 91). Because of Arendt's phenomenological "method," it is important to understand the loss of authority as a precondition for banality, not its cause. This would make spiritual desiccation the precondition to a new justification for action.

According to Arendt, "what distinguished these new totalitarian ideologists from their predecessors was that it was no longer primarily the 'idea' of the ideology ... which appealed to them, but the logical process which could be developed from it" (*Origins*, 472).

The "ice-cold reasoning" and the "mighty tentacle" of dialectics which "seizes you as in a vice" appears like a last support in a world where nobody is reliable and nothing can be relied upon. It is the inner coercion whose only content is the strict avoidance of contradictions that seems to confirm a man's identity outside all relationships with others. (*Origins*, 478)

The destratification of society, which in our era first appears as the equalization of social life, detaches thinking from an ordered reality and makes it obsolete as a political/social phenomenon. In other words, the solitary thinker has no place to go when leaving the private realm, and nothing to cling to as "guideposts" to help him through life.

The essence of totalitarian terror is immobilization, a paralysis that stops thinking; but it also halts action. Eichmann and Molotov, for example, were not accused of inertia, but of

acting in such a way as to explode "our tradition of thought." The extermination of millions may not spring from conviction but it certainly must spring from commitment. An empty mind is rudderless; what sends it in a certain direction? Political evil, by its nature, is rigorously organized, hence, it reckons a plotted course of action.

The answer to the question Arendt offers is not an end, as in outcome, which in this case was already decided by Hitler and Stalin. Nor is it a goal, a finality, which was decided for Hitler and Stalin by Nature (the dominance of the Aryan race) and History (the ascendancy of the working class). Such planning, norms, and purposes were never the province of the lower-level functionary whose mind could remain teleologically uncluttered. There was never a "why" for mental fixation, only a "how." Why calls ends into question, it subordinates means to the future. When an individual asks "why," he is seeking meaning for his own acts. He is trying to fit the present into some (always unknown) future state of affairs. "Why" connects the finite to the infinite, the individual to the variant possibilities of human destiny. Arendt's theoretical insight into the empty mind that could be filled with bureaucratic orders to kill was first depicted in *Origins* as "a meticulous, calculated correctness" and "stubborn dullness" (*Origins*, 327). How different is this from banality?

Almost a parody of this uncluttered mind is Rudolf Höess, the commandant of Auschwitz, who personally claimed the murders of two million people. "Whether this mass extermination of the Jews was necessary or not was something on which I could not allow myself to form an opinion, for I lacked the necessary breadth of view." As a response to the statement that he could have disobeyed orders or even killed Himmler, he held that, "I do not believe that of all the thousands of SS officers there could have been found a single one capable of such a thought."²¹

Metaphysically, "how" is instrumental; it is procedural and presupposes an end that has been decided beforehand. The person who never asks "why" has instrumentalized himself. He has objectified his existence for the sake of the subjective "why," or for those who have already asked the question and come up with the answer. It is this instrumental mentality that finds its parallel, its usefulness, in the totalitarian "principle of action," the "logicality of ideological thinking" (*Origins*, 474).

This is the point at which the mind is reduced to a mechanism. Logicality is Arendt's most significant contribution to the understanding of ideology, its operational guise. And it is the perfect instrument for dealing with the *tedium vitae* of modern bureaucratized existence. For those not a part of ideological formation or articulation (the ideologists), logicality fills the mind with procedure, a process that functions on behalf

of something else. Arendt tells us how this works: "As soon as logic as a movement of thought—and not as a necessary control of thinking—is applied to an idea, this idea is transformed into a premise" (*Origins*, 469). Logic "as a control for thinking" seeks factual knowledge (as a relation to human experience) and internal consistency, to approximate some facet of truth. However, ideological logic, "as a movement of thought," carries the individual along with the premise that sets the logical process into motion. The human mind, especially the (lonely) one that has lost the capacity for individual judgment, bows down to this inexorable mental force, "drawing conclusions in the manner of mere argumentation" (*Origins*, 470).

This concludes in the destruction of contingency, spontaneity, or, as in Arendt, a new beginning. Thus the whole process, that is, the movement of logic from the premise toward the ordained future, cannot be interpreted by a new idea since this would lead to new and unpredicted consequences. Nor can a new experience penetrate this mental process since this would actually contravene the very procedure by which the logic moves and seeks fulfillment. A new event, or an unprecedented experience, violates the internal dynamic of History and Nature.

This helps explain the need for revisionism, whose real objective is the conforming of events to the logical premise that begins the mental operation. A new action shocks the logicity of individual mental activity. We have now reached the point at which ideologists plumb the depths of the subconscious mind to look for hidden, unconscious remnants of old-order thinking. The most obvious example of this on a mass scale was Mao Zedung's (1957) "Let a Hundred Flowers Bloom" campaign. This euphemistically titled propaganda campaign, whose real purpose was the "rectification of thought," is more obviously visible in its original title, "On the Correct Handling of Contradictions Among the People."

Here we see how the process of argumentation becomes the very basis of human understanding. The process becomes a metaphysical tyrant whose sole concern is the fulfillment of the premise of the ideology. That this was not an individual but a mass phenomenon became evident when the ideologies were elevated to national doctrine, and when "free public opinion" adopted them, and when so-called intellectuals could not think independently of them. Again, we turn to Eichmann as the prototypical ideologue: "When confronted with situations for which such routine procedures did not exist, he was helpless, and his cliché-ridden language produced on the stand, as it had evidently done in his official life, a kind of macabre comedy" (*Mind*, 4). Understood metaphysically, the mind now submits to logic as "a never-ending process" from which man, *qua* thinker, engenders his thoughts. The individual takes his bearings from the process. Illustrative was Eichmann's constant reliance on

"cliches, stock phrases, adherence to conventional, standardized codes of expression ..." which served to insulate him against reality; that is, against the demands of new facts and events (*Mind*, 4).

This rather stock functionary portrayed by Arendt formed much of the criticism leveled at her by the Jewish community, the notion of a "desk criminal." Lionel Abel's criticism rests on two interrelated propositions. The first seems to be a variation of the "aberrational thesis": Arendt's implication that Eichmann was an "utterly replaceable" instrument in the death factories, when he was little more than a civilizational pariah. Secondly, Abel diminishes "totalitarianism" as a worthy category for political/social analysis: "no state can be as powerful as Miss Arendt thought 'The Totalitarian State' to be."²² This latter argument, widespread among social scientists, denies the "novelty thesis," to wit, that a new and more monstrous form of human organization has entered the world. Taken together, Abel's indictments appear as a veiled defense of the denouement central to the assumptions of the social sciences generally, and which Arendt sees as one "origin" of totalitarianism.

But many of Arendt's critics disconnect her conclusions from the political and social history that telescope into the "origins" (or "elements" as she prefers) of totalitarianism, failing to recall that it did not spring into the world like the Owl of Minerva. It crept into the world and was aided by Manichean (Helvetius, Holbach) and Gnostic forces (Comte, Hegel) long before Hitler, Lenin, or Stalin seized the reins of power. The absence of convictions regarding truth and falsity, fact and fiction, is what made Eichmann "utterly replaceable." With modest variations any mass man is likely to fit this convictionless profile of Arendt's.

Yet convictionlessness is an absence of belief, not a dearth of content. The thoughtless functionaries of totalitarianism were not murderers whose minds were empty of content. Instead, they were men who had lost the capacity for the kind of discriminating judgment that must constantly choose between things (experiences) that are given. In this case what was given was not natural events or spontaneous human action, but a formula for reaching conclusions. Their respective ideologies were particularly well suited for this conclusion-getting since, as Arendt puts it, their prime mental function is "to explain everything and every occurrence by deducing it from a single premise" (*Origins*, 468). This becomes the basic function of the ideology seen in terms of metaphysics: methodizing human thought.

The distinction between the *ratio* of the Enlightenment and the ancient *nous* lies in the difference between the search for knowledge and the quest for meaning. The despiritualization of the Western mind that issued from the Enlightenment finally

reappeared in the materialized theories that transformed the god of the whole into the god of the particular, race and class. While claiming a cosmology formerly understood in terms of God's intention for man on earth, the new knowledge tries to do what God formerly did, explain man's purpose in terms of the forces arrayed against him. Unlike the old seekers of truth, who sought the divine so they might conform themselves to it, the modern "clerics," says Benda, "desire to abase the values of knowledge before the values of action."²³ Knowledge is then no longer what humbles men because it stands outside of them. Instead it is merely, but politically, an interest of men who are divided by it. That is why, as Benda observes, "Our age is indeed the age of the *intellectual organization of political hatreds*. It will be one of its chief claims to notice in the moral history of humanity"²⁴ (author's italics).

Of course Arendt was relentless in pointing up the quasi-scientific ambitions of ideology and its attempt to make itself *the* method for "knowing" the world. She observes how the magnetic claim to knowledge attracts the thoughtless and finally makes thinking unnecessary. Indeed, this led to one of her more dismal conclusions; that "the self-coercive force of logicity is mobilized [by ideological propaganda] lest anybody ever start thinking—which as the freest and purest of all human activities is the very opposite of the compulsory process of deduction" (*Origins*, 473).

Alain Besancon sees the shallowness of this scientificity as an "attitude of mind" which, by virtue of its superficiality, is a kind of gnosis. "It is an imperfect model of ideological thinking, but it is the only one which can provide it with any depth of historical perspective."²⁵ Knowledge is a retrospective of empirical reality, it gives depth to human existence. This "depth of historical perspective" is inverted in ideology and projected toward a future seen in terms of a goal. Here Eric Voegelin captures the Gnostic element, its real essence as false knowledge. "The fallacy of gnosis consists in the immanentization of transcendental truth." Voegelin locates the falsity of the Gnostic formulation in the original inversion of Hegel's Idea: "Hegel's reality of the unfolding Idea is abolished and empirical reality has become meaningful as if it were an Idea."²⁶ This immediately reduces reality to that which can be worked on, managed, and "reformulated" to coincide with the "idea" about it. The dangers in such a proposition are obvious.

Arendt was aware of the possibilities of transforming reality by degrading it to an object of materialist logic. This is why she understood so well the compelling aspects (the totalitarian nature) of ideology. Once the premise ("starting point") is accepted *everything* is swept aside. Metaphysically, "Nothing matters but consistency." This formed the basis of "supersense," a coinage by Arendt that means the remolding of man as a

thinking animal. This process requires the restructuring of the dramaturgy of human history. Rather than seeing the world composed of individual men who perform discrete acts, ideology seeks "to make the world consistent, to prove that its respective supersense has been right" (*Origins*, 458). Hence, all present experiences are "rectified," that is, conformed to Nature (the natural fight of races) or History (the economic struggle of classes).

Supersense substitutes for the world of common sense, thus a sense common to all men, by explaining the finite actions of men in terms of some historical mechanic that set those actions into motion. Hence, it trivializes action and abases the moral responsibility men have for it. This is a reversal of the Greeks, who stole responsibility from the gods and gave it to man. This only enhances the spiritualization of the ideology (and the ideologists) by creating a *logos* of nonresponsibility; a mythical account of human impotence due to the "history that acts behind the backs of men." Nowhere is this more evident than with Marx's famous dictum in *The German Ideology*: "It is not consciousness that determines life; but life that determines consciousness."²⁷ "Knowledge" about this "consciousness" replaces the rule of God, and becomes the hegemony of the mundane.

Ideologies, with their respective supersense, fictionalize human experience through "systems based upon a single opinion that proved strong enough to attract and persuade a majority of people and broad enough to lead them through the various experiences and situations of an average modern life" (*Origins*, 159).²⁸ It is important to understand here that Arendt is not suggesting that supersense will alter human nature, although she clearly believes it to be at stake (*Origins*, 459). The supersensual change in experience (i.e., the rectification of experience) alters the human response to it, thus affecting the common world and the sense that is made of it. The individual finds his place in the functional premise of the new society, which has been incorporated into the new historical movement. The prosaic is now given historical significance, thus bestowing grandeur on the individual in his conformity to History.

The rectification of experiences, or the fabrication of new ones, whose most conspicuous features are hatred on the one side, and the gullible belief in perfection on the other side, demands the formation of mental processes that can sustain the movements long enough for them to seize and maintain power. This process has to go beyond self-interest, which is immediate and cannot sustain the movement into an indefinite future. To sustain itself it must also go beyond simple idealism, which takes its bearings from experiences and is satisfied with practical changes. Yet it must be able to preclude heresy from the rank and file which operates from a principle of visible

reality. Simultaneously, the rank and file (the masses) must be able to connect the telos of the ideology to the premise that sets the process into motion. This is where the process of historification transforms subjective human achievements, from which men reckon and search for guideposts, into objects of willful reconstruction, or "remolding," as Arendt says.

3.

The historification of man requires the mechanization of the thinking process, the formation of a kind of mental mimicry. Arendt illustrates its operation: "Comprehension is achieved by the mind's imitating, either logically, or dialectically, the laws of 'scientifically' established movements which through the process of imitation it becomes integrated" (*Origins*, 471). This abolishes the moral ontology of the individual and transfers it to the ideologists. Thus Leon Trotsky (following Engels) justified violence ("lying and worse") in terms of economic ascendancy and conformity to an inexorable history: "The liberating morality of the proletariat ... deduces a rule for conduct from the laws of the development of society, thus primarily from the class struggle, this law of laws."²⁹

The premise of the ideology now forms a new principle of human action and replaces the axiological formation of old-order thinking. Historical events, and the finite human actions that shaped them, are no longer contingent nor do they fall within the pale of human responsibility. Each action, every event, must seek its "moral" (internalized) justification within the ordained history as determined by the Leader or Party. Leon Trotsky, who probably understood the mechanics of this process better than anyone, reduced the subjectification of history to a determination of the vanguard: "We can only be right with and by the Party, for history has provided no other way of being in the right" (*Origins*, 307n).

Now reduced to a process of mental abstraction, the human mind must be reconciled to the outside world so concrete experiences can be confirmed by the process of imitation. When the mind externalizes itself in order to locate objects for determination it fixes, in this case, on finality, the beacon for ideological thinking. It is this mental reconciliation to the telos of the ideology that coerces all facts, all human data (the reality of experience), into a deduction from the premise. Hence every human activity, all potential contradictions, are reduced to a concealment of the "true" reality that will be unveiled with the future unfolding of the process.

This is where ideology annihilates individual judgment by replacing it with "an axiomatically accepted premise [for mental fixation] deducing everything else from it; that is, it proceeds with a consistency that exists nowhere in the realm of reality"

(*Origins*, 471). As Arendt develops this argument ideologies actually mock reality by seeking to parallel its vital functions. This mocking not only does away with thinking, but clearly precludes the possibility of free will—the individual as ontological cause. The process of logicity, as she calls it, precludes the spontaneous will because it is rendered superfluous.³⁰ Since the will is the “organ of the future” the individual is confined to the task at hand.

Logicity applied to externality, the world of things, Arendt identifies as “fictionalizing,” and she describes it variously as “phantasm,” “unreality,” and that which the ideologists use to fabricate a new mankind. Truth is not an effort to order and understand the discrete incidents of human existence. Nor is it what truth can only be, a retrospective—the mind’s reliance on memory to measure what has been given to the senses against what it already knows. There is no accumulation of knowledge here, simply a reordering of reality in light of the telos. In the name of ideological consistency, truth becomes prospective; an activist formulation, not for ascertaining reality but for bringing it about. This is why ideologies can only mock explanation, since the truth or falsity of an event is circumscribed by an unreachable past (by experience) and an indefinite future that is closed to thought.

Human minds are now forced into metaphysical confusion. There is an abyss, nothing for thought to cling to as it makes its evanescent journey into withdrawal where it must search for a *sensus communis*. Trotsky was plainly aware of this void when he argued that, for a Revolutionary Marxist, “there can be no contradiction between personal morality and the interests of the Party, since the Party embodies in his consciousness the very highest tasks and aims of mankind.”³¹ The individual must now internalize the norms and, so far as possible, the means for their determination. This means an effort to imitate historical consciousness as interpreted by the Party. Hence, with Marxism, “humanity” and “mankind” remain abstractions whose determination is “made” by social reality, the class struggle. Accordingly, “humanity” is what *will be* once the class struggle has been resolved. The Manichean elements are obvious. Equally important politically, a hieratic rulership replaces the visible Church and guides men explicitly through temporal life.

There is now a unity of thought and purpose set to a reconstituted reality; not a common world but an identical one, providing each one starts from the same premise. Hitler understood this when he told his followers, “All that you are, you are through me; all that I am, I am through you alone” (*Origins*, 325). However, this new world is not formed from a shared opinion of individual men or a common aspiration, but from “the structure of their minds, and this they cannot have in common, strictly speaking; their faculty of reasoning can only

happen to be the same in everybody" (*HC*, 283). We can see here a possible rank ordering to Arendt's "destructive urge" because it emanates from the ideologists outward (following the "onion-like" structure of totalitarianism). One possible source for this structured "urge," veiled as it is under administrative *arcana*, is Nietzsche's *Schadenfreude* ("malicious joy"). Another possible source, given Arendt's affection for Dostoevsky, is the "possessed," those who find a "depository for their consciences" and are spared "the grave anxiety of choice."³² Evil, then, and not vice, is the antithesis of virtue, since it is the commodification of action in a Society that robs the individual of personality and the freedom to defy codes and conventions. The *logos* of nonresponsibility is completed now. Leader and led can abrogate moral responsibility in an orgy of symbiotic self-abnegation. Together they would fulfill the logic of historical development.

4.

Thus far our effort has been on results, the consequences of a system of ideas or doctrinal thought Arendt identifies as banal. Coeval with banal murdering, mechanical acts that reflect mechanized thinking, is the disappearance of the moral universe. This universe, so far as it can be understood politically, is grounded in the historical development of a people, what they permit and what they point toward, as a justification for their existence. It is their being understood as memory. But under the conditions of historical materialism the moral cosmology is reoriented to the very forces of history, the intramundane world itself.

But Arendt claims that banal murdering, thoughtless evil, is new. It therefore defies, or stands outside of memory; that is, the historical sense a people has of itself and which is shared in common. It appears, then, that we are dealing with the breakdown of memory through a people's redefinition of human purpose. Understood historically, do Eichmann and Molotov signal the end of an epoch in Western civilization, or the beginning of a new one? Their actions would certainly confirm the *illusion* of progress. Has human status depended entirely on civic status, what Arendt, following Kant, calls the *sensus communis*? Politically, do ideologies that seek political rule and imperialistic grandeur constitute the end of the civilizational epoch that began with Hellenic and Hebraic thought? Morally, is the banal mind the religious mind emptied of divine content? Maybe, just maybe, banality is the inversion of the soul, or following Plato, the ascendancy of a different ruling part.

Evil is not just the absence of goodness, but the absence of goodness paves the way for evil, incubating its variegated forms. Nowhere does the need for convention, the "public realm," demonstrate its moral significance more than with Eichmann's

candid statement that, "Nobody ... came to me and reproached me for anything in the performance of my duties (*EJ*, 131). Arendt is not concerned here with customs and habits, but with what caused their disappearance. Inverting the soul understood as a natural phenomenon or a theological category has the effect of inverting the origins of good and evil. The former universalism that used to subordinate all men in their individual capacity for perfectibility has been usurped by a particularity (race or class) that runs "counter to our tradition of thought." The soul, or its incarnate symbolization in class or race, is transformed into a material or biological contingency that reduces good and evil to an accident of one's place in history.

A perverse soul confronts the good as an adversary. It has turned on itself in favor of something else, something outside itself. If one takes the Thomistic view (and, by inference, Aristotle's) that reason is a gift from God so man might know the good and thereby act on it, then evil is a perversion. But Arendt is describing *banal* evil; it is a special type, it is political, methodized, of epochal proportion. It is not something in history but something that makes history. It is not reasonable, hence limited. Yet it has to do with reason, or reasoning; calculation without a conclusion, a sequence without a consequence. The eschaton of the eschatology of totalitarianism is specific, the destruction of all non-Aryans and the elimination of the bourgeois, but it is remote: There are always "remnants," "counter-revolutionaries," enemies of the "new order." Banal evil appears to be reason turned against itself without negating itself. It is under the conditions of totalitarianism that we have become aware of what happens to civilization when thinking is routinized. Banal murdering may be one consequence of the Enlightenment—a grotesque shallowness.

But political evil is emptiness of intent. It is not banal because it has been bureaucratized, as with Eichmann and Molotov. Whether the death camps of Europe or the starvation fields of the Ukraine, bureaucratization suggests only the extremity of the techniques of evil; it does not explain its source. Evil has become banal because its justification (its purpose) lies, or is claimed to lie, outside the actions of men: Nature defined in terms of race, and History determined by economics. Therefore, its source cannot be intentionality but helplessness, an abject responsibility for having been caught in a certain moment in History. The instrumentalization of man now assumes a spurious grandeur as doctrines of historical progress conclude by methodizing human thought. Ideologies then set thoughtlessness to motion.

While Arendt's formulation of memory is too complex for us here, we must underscore its importance to her political

anthropology. Understood as the history of beings, and therefore a history of human experiences, it forms the background against which thinking actually takes place. It has its genesis, of course, in her affection for Greek thought, which gives us Remembrance (*Mnemosyne*), the mother of the muses who "saves all things." She understands how action not only forms the field of expression for politics but draws from the reservoir of high human types that actually situate us "between past and future."³³ This is why expurgating history, creating what she calls "the hole of oblivion," becomes a vital function of the ideology and a requisite to establishing its supersense beyond doubt.³⁴ This means that banality, methodized thinking, is set to work through a process of dematerialization, a purging of antecedent actions and events. This concludes in the obliteration of human activities and the relationships they have engendered. Marx's "dead weight of previous generations" can no longer guide future ones.

In a materialized modernity, obliteration serves the useful dual purpose of satisfying (i.e., filling) an empty mind, while giving it a sense of direction (purposefulness) in externality formerly occupied by remembrance. As an objectifying activity obliteration also serves one of the prime functions of the ideology; it rectifies history by eliminating antecedent thought objects, hence remembrance. This means that History or Nature is corrected by removing "things" from the intended development of class or race. The temporal mind, viewed from the metaphysic of human conduct, is then reduced to a binary field of expression; a present and a future, the past is obliterated as a repository of individual action. This means that human experience loses any didactic value entirely.

Finally, without remembrance, thinking becomes useless, superfluous, because it has lost the objects of thought, while simultaneously losing the world as a reckoning. One of the defining human faculties, the need to think, has lost its connection to humanity. While this thinking poses a danger in Arendt's formulation, because it can emerge with unanticipated aspirations, it can also dissolve all theoretical constructions in favor of a new beginning. This is why she observed first in the *Origins* that "Freedom as an inner capacity of man is identical with the capacity to begin, just as freedom as a political reality is identical with a space of movement between men" (*Origins*, 473). It is this "inner capacity" that occupied Arendt in her last, and most philosophical work.

Conclusion

Hannah Arendt's basic concern as a philosopher is to establish the authenticity of human existence in a factual world into which we have been thrown as strangers. This corresponds to what she considers the fundamental absurdity of the human

condition which, she claims, consists in the "homelessness of Man in the World." The idea of deracinated "Man in the World" became the fundamental social/psychological fact of modern mass movements which, according to Arendt, was the main ingredient of totalitarianism. While she expresses it variously, this homelessness laid the groundwork for political destruction. But none of her political categories seemed appropriate for a homecoming. She was driven inward herself to use philosophy to overcome philosophy; that is, to use the tools of metaphysics to overcome the tendency, so irresistible since Kant, to make freedom and human existence products of the mind. This is the source of modern intellectual arrogance; it marks the crisis of modern philosophy. For Arendt, this is the modern attempt to sever thinking from doing.

It was precisely this crisis that drove Arendt into an uncomfortable battle with Immanuel Kant. While it was Kant to whom she turned for her theory of judging, it was also Kant who abandoned Man to his own Being. Her disagreement with Kantian ontology is most visible in Kant's destruction of the ancient notion of Being which carries within it, from an existential point of view, the modern idea of nonpolitical freedom.³⁵ The thrust of Kantian ontology, as Arendt sees it, is to establish the autonomy of man, which destroyed the ancient conception of Being and thought, which was based on a preestablished harmony between Man and the world. Arendt wants to restore the original cosmology, but with the decisive difference that man understand his role in bringing about the natural order. But according to Kant, Man (as a universal) can determine his own freedom only by acting according to the good will.

However, these determinations are ultimately based on subjectivity, which is the realm of freedom, yet they are forced into the objective sphere once the individual encounters externality—the outside world. Thus Kant eventually freed Man to the world, but finally enslaved him to his own Being. Politically speaking, Kant liberated Man from himself, but he could not do the same once Man entered the world. It is as though Man could be in the world while remaining a creature of it. This resulted in the existential hero: Nietzsche's *amor fati*, Heidegger's "Resoluteness," Camus's "Defiance," and earlier Kierkegaard's "Great Leap." The problem here for politics is the necessity of the archetype, and the final potential for its perversion.

While Arendt has relied on the archetype, Kant's "exemplars" as the "go-cart" of judgments, and the paradigmatic significance of Achilles, she clearly wants us to understand politics as the realm of plurality. Birth, death, and plurality are the antidotes to despair, the counters to the totalitarian tendency of mass democracies. This is not a proposition, but a conclusion: "Totalitarian government can be safe only to the

extent that it can mobilize man's own will power in order to force him into that gigantic movement of History or Nature which supposedly uses mankind as its material and *knows neither birth nor death*" (*Origins*, 473). Thus Kant's attempt to consign freedom to the inner sanctum leads to its annihilation in public life.

Hannah Arendt has too often and too easily been criticized for placing action at the center of her political theory, and it is certainly central to what she calls the "public realm." But her last work, *The Life of the Mind*, while never completed, when combined with her earlier works, clearly demonstrates that "politics" is not the center of her moral cosmology. A "radical evil" (Kant's term) drove her finally to the *radix*, the root of man, where Kant helped her connect the *interior domus* of every individual to all individuals, past and future. This is the only way the "sensus" can have a universal commonality, and allow us to speak of something called "humanity." But Arendt understands that this inner sanctum has no *topos*, no place in the world where men can organize life together. This is precisely why she formulated a politics, a *polis*, that is "a kind of organized remembrance," where "I appear to others, and where others appear to me" (*HC*, 198, 199). The failure of this politics leads to fictionalizing human existence, a romanticization of human limitlessness, where "neither the reality of one's self, of one's own identity, nor the reality of the surrounding world can be established beyond doubt" (*HC*, 208). Yet if men do not organize or seek to live together there would be no need to speak of good and evil, nor of politics either.

While seeking to understand the requirements of justice, Hannah Arendt, as Jew and philosopher, resisted the temptation to locate the most monstrous acts in history by prosecuting Adolf Eichmann as an instrument of history. Eichmann was not on trial in Jerusalem for hating Jews, discriminating by unpleasanties, or disliking or even hating categories of people. He was on trial for what he had done. She notes unambiguously in *Eichmann in Jerusalem* that, "On trial are his deeds, not the suffering of the Jews, not the German people or mankind, not even anti-Semitism and racism" (*EJ*, 5).

Anti-Semitism, a tangible, concrete, sub-specie of the generalized body type of racism, is condemnable as a particularization of the generalization that is condemnable; it is not prosecutable. Hannah Arendt, a Zionist and exile from Nazi Germany, could not hold classes of people responsible for feelings or thoughts. She understood that Eichmann was not guilty of making history, only for his direct participation in it.

Notes

¹ Hannah Arendt, *Eichmann in Jerusalem* (New York: The Viking Press, 1965), 26, 41-42 (cited as *EJ*; Hannah Arendt, *The Life of the*

Mind (New York: Harcourt Brace Jovanovich, 1978), 4 (cited as *Mind*).

² Hannah Arendt, *The Jew as Pariah*, edited by Ron Feldman (New York, N.Y.: Grove Press, 1978), 251 (cited as *JP*).

³ Hannah Arendt, *The Origins of Totalitarianism*, 3rd ed. (New York, N.Y.: Harcourt Brace and World, 1966), xxx–xxxi (cited as *Origins*).

⁴ *Ibid.*, xxxi.

⁵ Richard Bernstein, *Hannah Arendt and the Jewish Question* (Cambridge, Mass.: The MIT Press, 1996), 149, 151.

⁶ Hannah Arendt, "On the Nature of Totalitarianism," in *Hannah Arendt, Essays in Understanding, 1930–1954*, edited by Jerome Kohn (New York, N.Y.: Harcourt Brace and Co., 1994), 328.

⁷ Bernstein concentrates almost exclusively on the Nazis, which misleads him to ignore the larger theoretical concern of Arendt, whose real analysis is totalitarianism as a "novel form of government."

⁸ "Nature of Totalitarianism," 350. In the same essay, she dramatizes the basic irrelevance of the content of ideology to its mass adherents. She calls the "shirt wearers" those who change from "one kind of eternal law" to another, from "brown shirts to red shirts and back again," and whichever one they embrace at the time "they are saved" (356).

⁹ "Nature of Totalitarianism," 357.

¹⁰ Philip Rieff, "The Theology of Politics: Reflections on Totalitarianism as the Burden of Our Time" (1952), in *The Feeling Intellect*, edited by Jonathan Imber (Chicago, Ill.: University of Chicago Press, 1990), 87.

¹¹ *Origins*, xxx.

¹² Hannah Arendt, *The Human Condition* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1958), prologue, 5 (cited *HC*).

¹³ Bernstein, *Hannah Arendt and the Jewish Question*, 171.

¹⁴ *Ibid.*, 176.

¹⁵ Hannah Arendt, *Between Past and Future* (New York, N.Y.: The Viking Press, 1968), 15 (cited as *BPF*). Her biographer, Young-Bruehl, says this was Arendt's "favorite book" because it is an effort to recover traditional concepts.

¹⁶ In "Philosophy and Sociology," she says that "Only when people no longer see their existence in community as given ... does something like ideology arise.... Only when the individual's place in the world is determined by economic status and not by tradition does he become homeless" (*Essays in Understanding*, 41).

¹⁷ This entirely "modern" view seems confirmed by Sylva Benhabib in *The Reluctant Modernism of Hannah Arendt*. Benhabib writes an entire book to prove that Arendt's philosophy is not only modernist and feminist, but also concerned with "identity politics." But she concludes forlornly with the self-evident, that "Arendt remains the mother who eludes us" (Thousand Oaks, Calif.: Sage Publications, 1996, xxxiii).

¹⁸ In the introduction to *Mind* she observes that "if anything is dead, it can only be the traditional *thought* of God. And something similar is true of the end of philosophy and metaphysics" (10).

¹⁹ George Kateb, *Hannah Arendt: Politics, Conscience, Evil* (New Jersey: Rowman and Allanheld, 1984), 54.

²⁰ Kateb, 189–190.

²¹ Rudolf Höess, *Commandant of Auschwitz* (New York, N.Y.:

Popular Library, 1961), 135. Originally published in 1951, this is Höess's autobiography about his succession to captain of Auschwitz from 1941–1943. It was written in prison before his execution at Nuremberg.

²² Lionel Abel, "The Aesthetics of Evil," *Partisan Review* 30:3 (Summer 1963): 211, 229. Gershom Scholem, with whom Bernstein wrestles, attacks Arendt for her "treatment" of Jewish "participants" in the Final Solution. But Scholem indicts Arendt for reducing Eichmann's crimes to a "catchword," banality. See Bernstein's defense, esp. chapter 8.

²³ Julien Benda, *The Treason of the Intellectuals*, translated by R. Aldington (New York, N.Y.: W. W. Norton, 1928), 148.

²⁴ Benda, *The Treason of the Intellectuals*, 27.

²⁵ Alain Besancon, *The Rise of the Gulag: The Intellectual Origins of Leninism* (New York: Continuum, 1981), 9.

²⁶ Eric[h] Voegelin, *Political Religions* (New York, N.Y.: The Edwin Mellon Press, 1986; first published in 1938), 265.

²⁷ Karl Marx, *The German Ideology* (New York, N.Y.: International Publishers, 1970), 47.

²⁸ The "theological" implications of this supersense cannot be ignored. In her correspondence with Jaspers, Arendt responds to his direct question: "Hasn't Jahwe faded too far out of sight?" Her answer reveals the superfluousness of men and their spontaneity. "If an individual man qua man were omnipotent, then there is in fact no reason why man in the plural should exist at all—just as in monotheism it is only God's omnipotence that makes him ONE. So, in the same way, the omnipotence of an individual man would make men superfluous." It is certainly warranted to include here the omnipotence of a race, class, or tribe. See Hannah Arendt and Karl Jaspers, *Correspondence: 1926–1969* (New York, N.Y.: Harcourt Brace, 1992), 166.

²⁹ Sidney Hook, *Marx and the Marxists* (Florida: Robert Krieger, 1982), 97.

³⁰ Besancon dramatizes the effect of this logicity on such leaders as Lenin, who held a sycophantic fascination with Marx's "science" as movement. Lenin was the "gnostic, in the grip of the saving gnosis, felt himself reborn and that he had become another filled with a new content" (Besancon, *The Rise of the Gulag*, 9).

³¹ Hook, *Marx and the Marxists*, 98.

³² See the brilliant analysis of Henri de Lubac, *The Drama of Atheist Humanism*, translated by Edith Riley (London: Sheed and Ward, 1949), esp. 199.

³³ Arendt's hostility toward scientism is widely known. But in her essay "Tradition and the Modern Age," she underscores her hostility to modernity. "Since the rise of modern science," she concludes, "whose spirit is expressed in Cartesian philosophy of doubt and mistrust, the conceptual framework of the tradition has not been secure." But worse, "The spiritual homelessness of modern man finds its first expressions in this Cartesian perplexity (*BPF*, 39, 38. Also, see *Mind* 15, 14, 177).

³⁴ Hannah Arendt, "The Hole of Oblivion," *Jewish Frontier* (July 1947): 23; *BPF*, "Tradition and the Modern Age," 39.

³⁵ Wayne Allen, "Hannah Arendt: Existential Phenomenology and Political Freedom," *Philosophy and Social Criticism* 9.2 (Summer 1983): 173.

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- . "Tradition and the Modern Age." *Between Past and Future*. New York: Viking Press, 1968, 17–40.
- . "Understanding and Politics." *Partisan Review* (July–August 1953): 20–24. The necessity of "understanding" as a counter to totalitarian thinking is visible in the fact that this essay is based on an earlier piece titled, "On the Nature of Totalitarianism: An Essay in Understanding."
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